Only one-hundredth of 1 percent of all the water in the world is readily available for human use. Drinking water is also not distributed equally, being naturally scarcer in hot, arid areas of the world than in temperate zones.

Population pressures and wealth also have an impact on water supplies. The UN believes everyone should have access to at least 88 pints (50 liters) of freshwater a day, but people in Mozambique manage on less than 21 pints (10 liters) a day, while the average American enjoys almost 656 pints (310 liters).

Around the world, water sources are also being bought up by large corporations. Some scientists warn that, if our current usage patterns continue and population rates grow at their current rate, by 2030 global demand for clean water will exceed supply by 40 percent.

Future plans

New strategies are evidently required to save the world from human destruction. Transition engineering, an emerging multi-disciplinary field, may help. It aims to use existing businesses, organizations, and systems to find innovative ways to minimize environmental impacts and manage resources.

Some progress is being made, in part thanks to campaigning by people like Naomi Klein. A number of European and Asian countries, including the UK, have decided to phase out fossil-fuel vehicles. In other areas, however, socioeconomic and political problems remain obstacles to reform. As “Our Common Future” stated, meeting humanity’s goals and aspirations responsibly “will require the active support of us all.”